EXT. PHIL'S TIRE TOWN CHALLENGER - EVENING

A. Donaldson: 2, 6, 6 - 30

P. Zweig: 6, 2, 5 - 30

Thwaccckkk!

Patrick sends his first serve into the net.

Reset.

Thwaccckkk!

It goes wide.

LINE JUDGE
OUT!

A few people gasp at the double fault.

Match Point.

UMPIRE
Thirty - Forty.

Patrick looks at Tashi. He bounces the ball and goes into his service motion.

Thwaccckkk!

LINE JUDGE
OUT!

Patrick resets, takes a deep breath, bounces the ball, and pauses in the middle of his service motion.

He looks at Art, crouched down, ready to win the match.

He looks over at Tashi, holding her breath.

He looks back at Art, who's wondering what's taking so long.

He starts the motion over again. He stops.

UMPIRE
Time violation. Warning, Zweig.

Patrick smiles to himself. Tashi looks on, confused.

He goes into his service motion again, but this time, he does Art's service motion, just like when they were

eighteen.

Thwaccckkk!

Art's too shocked to even move for it. He just stands there, frozen, looking at Patrick.

The ball lands in.

UMPIRE (CONT'D)
Deuce.

Neither man moves. They stare at each other across the net like gunslingers in a western. Tashi looks back and forth between both of them, no idea what's going on.

Art looks over at Tashi, then back at Patrick. Patrick nods.

ART
Fuck off.

Patrick smiles.

UMPIRE
Code violation. Audible obscenity.
Point penalty, Donaldson.

Some grumbles in the crowd.

Patrick moves over for his next serve. Art doesn't move.

Tashi looks at him. He looks back at her, totally cold.

UMPIRE (CONT'D)
Advantage, Zweig.

Art just keeps looking at Tashi.

UMPIRE (CONT'D)
Art?

ART
(not moving.)
He can serve.

UMPIRE
You need to get into position.

Beat. Still looking at Tashi, he backs up to the other side of the service line and just stands there.

Some confused grumbles in the crowd. Tashi looks at Art, then at Patrick, then back at Art. Art turns to Patrick,

still just standing there, racket at his side.

ART
Serve.

Patrick smiles and hits a soft-as-a-pillow underhand serve like he's feeding Art the ball in practice.

Art doesn't even move for it: he just lets it sail right by.

UMPIRE
Game, Zweig.

Some grumbles and scattered, confused applause in the crowd.

UMPIRE (CONT'D)
Six games all. Final set. Tie break. Donaldson to serve.

Tashi looks at Patrick, then at Art. He can see now that she understands exactly what's happening.

He turns to Patrick. They stand looking at each other: Let's really play now.

Art receives balls for his serve. Patrick readies himself for the return.

Art bounces the ball and goes into his service motion.

Thwacckkk!

He sends the ball screaming right at Patrick's head like he's trying to decapitate him. Patrick has to dodge it.

LINE JUDGE
OUT!

Art smiles. So does Patrick. Art resets.

Thwacckkkk!

He sends in another one, just as hot. This time it's good.

Patrick pounces on the return, and they rally. It's clear immediately that both of them are playing their best tennis in years, the best tennis of their lives. They smack the ball at each other furiously, vengefully, looking wildly alive.

As they trade blows, we settle on Tashi, her head swiveling back and forth between the two of them. Gradually, her look

of anxiety turns into one of exhilaration.

Thwacckkk!

Thwacckkk!

Thwacckkk!

Thwacckkk!

Each hit releases something in her. As the rally intensifies, the three of them start to form into a single, electrified unit. Tashi grits her teeth, clenches her fists, playing as Art, playing as Patrick, playing as the ball itself.

Thwacckkk!

Thwacckkk!

Thwacckkk!

Patrick's ball, coming in hot, hits the top of the net, slowing its trajectory. Art has to sprint to catch it as it drops shallow on his side.

Patrick, seeing this, also sprints towards the net in anticipation of Art's drop volley.

Art gets to the ball and rips it crosscourt, but Patrick gets his racket on it, sending a volley to Art's backhand.

Art's right there to meet it, and for a few moments, they volley rapidly back and forth at the net, neither of them able to miss. Tashi's head zips back and forth between them as Art and Patrick's volleys draw them closer and closer towards one another until they're right on top of each other at the net, rocketing the ball at each other's bodies.

Thwacckkk!

Thwacckkk!

Thwacckkk!

Thwacckkk!

Finally, Patrick lobs the ball up. Tashi watches, riveted, as Art launches himself into the air to smack it down in Patrick's face.

Patrick looks up, amazed. Art's racket CRACKS down on the ball.

As the ball lands in, Art collapses against the net, exhausted. Patrick's right there to catch him. The two of them embrace with the net in between them.

The crowd cheers. Tashi leaps to her feet.

TASHI
COME ON!!!!!

Cut to black.

END.